

D573

Understanding Substance Abuse & Addiction

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A 60-year-old retired mail carrier who enjoys fishing has taken a prescribed opioid for cancer pain for a year exactly as directed. When a dose is missed, he has sweating and aches. He shows no craving, no misuse, and no loss of control. His grandson visits every Sunday. How is his condition best described?

- A. Tolerance only, with no dependence.
- B. Addiction, since anyone taking opioids for a year is addicted.
- C. Physical dependence without addiction.
- D. Opioid use disorder, because he has withdrawal.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which pattern best fits a substance use disorder rather than physical dependence alone?

- A. Withdrawal symptoms after stopping a prescribed medication taken as directed.
- B. Repeatedly using more than intended and continuing despite losing a job and relationships.
- C. Needing a higher dose of a prescribed pain medication after months of use.
- D. Drinking one glass of wine with dinner.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A man who has not used cocaine for eight months drives past the apartment complex with a blue awning where he used to buy drugs. He suddenly feels a strong urge to use. He recently started a job at a warehouse. What best explains the urge?

- A. Withdrawal symptoms from stopping eight months ago.
- B. A lack of willpower, which is the sole cause of addiction.
- C. Cues linked to past use trigger dopamine-related craving in the brain's reward pathway.
- D. Stress from his new warehouse job.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A 14-year-old who plays trumpet in the school band has a parent with alcohol use disorder and friends who drink. She also has a close relationship with her grandmother, strong school attachment, and a coach who mentors her. Her school has a new gym. What is the best assessment of her risk?

- A. She will certainly develop an alcohol use disorder because of her parent.
- B. She has elevated risk from family history and peers, partly offset by strong protective factors.
- C. Her band participation is her main risk factor.
- D. She has no risk because she has supportive adults.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A school district that recently added solar panels offers a special program only for students whose parents are in treatment for substance use disorders, none of whom have used substances themselves. The district serves 12,000 students. What type of prevention is this?

- A. Indicated prevention.
- B. Treatment.
- C. Selective prevention.
- D. Universal prevention.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A college refers students who were cited twice for underage drinking to a brief counseling program. What type of prevention is this?

- A. Selective prevention.
- B. Universal prevention.
- C. Harm reduction.
- D. Indicated prevention.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A woman who works as a hair stylist says, "I know my drinking is hurting my health, and part of me wants to cut back, but it's how I relax, so I'm not sure." She has no plan or date to change. Her salon has four chairs. Which stage of change is she in?

- A. Contemplation.
- B. Preparation.
- C. Precontemplation.
- D. Action, since she has admitted the problem.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A man has set a quit date two weeks from now, removed alcohol from his home, and scheduled a clinic visit. Which stage is he in?

- A. Action.
- B. Contemplation.
- C. Maintenance.
- D. Preparation.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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9.

A client who drives a delivery truck tells a counselor, "Everyone keeps saying I drink too much, but I don't think it's that bad." The counselor's office has a large fish tank. Which response best reflects motivational interviewing?

- A. "You're in denial, and you need to admit you have a problem."
- B. "It sounds like you're tired of people telling you what to do. What, if anything, concerns you about your drinking?"
- C. "Confrontation always works best with people who deny problems."
- D. "Here are five reasons you must quit today."

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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10.

A county health department in a region known for its wineries starts giving free naloxone kits and fentanyl test strips to people who use drugs. A council member who owns a hardware store worries the program will increase drug use. What does the evidence show?

- A.** Such programs reduce overdose deaths and do not increase drug use.
- B.** They work only if people first agree to total abstinence.
- C.** They are useful only for people who have already stopped using.
- D.** They increase drug use by making it safer.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A patient with opioid use disorder who works as a carpenter wants a medication that blocks opioid effects and is not itself an opioid. He has completed detoxification and has been opioid-free for 10 days. His clinic is next to a bakery. Which medication fits?

- A.** Naltrexone.
- B.** Buprenorphine.
- C.** Naloxone, taken daily.
- D.** Methadone.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A friend says, “Methadone treatment is just replacing one addiction with another.” What is the most accurate response?

- A.** Methadone blocks opioids, so it is not an opioid at all.
- B.** Methadone is only for emergency overdose reversal.
- C.** True; any use of an opioid is addiction.
- D.** Methadone is a prescribed, monitored treatment that reduces cravings, withdrawal, and overdose deaths and supports recovery.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A 60-year-old retired mail carrier ~~who enjoys fishing~~ has taken a prescribed opioid for cancer pain for a year exactly as directed. When a dose is missed, he has sweating and aches. He shows no craving, no misuse, and no loss of control. ~~His grandson visits every Sunday.~~ How is his condition best described?

Target word: dependence vs. addiction **Decides:** Withdrawal without compulsive use or harm.

A	Dropped element	Drops the withdrawal symptoms, which show dependence.
B	Absolute language	Long-term prescribed use does not equal addiction.
C	Correct	Withdrawal is an expected response; there is no compulsive use.
D	Confusion set	Withdrawal during prescribed use does not by itself mean addiction.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

Which pattern best fits a substance use disorder rather than physical dependence alone?

Target word: identify addiction — reverse direction **Decides:** Compulsive use despite harm.

A	Inverted operation	That is dependence, not a disorder.
B	Correct	Loss of control and use despite harm define a use disorder.
C	Adjacent category	Tolerance alone is not addiction.
D	Confusion set	Low-risk use with no harm or loss of control.

3. Answer C Concept 2

A man who has not used cocaine for eight months drives past the apartment complex ~~with a blue awning~~ where he used to buy drugs. He suddenly feels a strong urge to use. ~~He recently started a job at a warehouse.~~ What best explains the urge?

Target word: why cues cause craving **Decides:** Learned cues activate the reward system.

A	Adjacent category	Acute withdrawal has long passed; this is cue-triggered craving.
B	Absolute language	Ignores well-documented brain changes.
C	Correct	The reward system learns to respond to drug-associated cues.
D	Camouflage	The urge appeared at the cue location.

4. Answer B Concept 3

A 14-year-old ~~who plays trumpet in the school band~~ has a parent with alcohol use disorder and friends who drink. She also has a close relationship with her grandmother, strong school attachment, and a coach who mentors her. ~~Her school has a new gym.~~ What is the best assessment of her risk?

Target word: combine risk and protective factors **Decides:** Real risk factors offset in part by strong protective factors.

A	Absolute language	Family history raises risk but is not destiny.
B	Correct	Risk and protective factors combine; neither decides the outcome alone.
C	Inverted operation	Structured activities are usually protective.
D	Dropped element	Drops the family and peer risk factors.

5. Answer C Concept 4

A school district ~~that recently added solar panels~~ offers a special program only for students whose parents are in treatment for substance use disorders, none of whom have used substances themselves. ~~The district serves 12,000 students.~~ What type of prevention is this?

Target word: prevention level **Decides:** A higher-risk group with no individual signs of use.

A	Confusion set	Indicated targets individuals already showing early signs of use.
B	Inverted operation	Treatment follows a diagnosis; these students have not used substances.
C	Correct	Targets a group at elevated risk, not individuals showing use.
D	Adjacent category	Universal would include all 12,000 students.

6. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

A college refers students who were cited twice for underage drinking to a brief counseling program. What type of prevention is this?

Target word: classify by who is served **Decides:** Individuals already showing early signs of use.

A	Confusion set	Selective is based on group risk, not individual behavior.
B	Inverted operation	Universal serves everyone regardless of risk.
C	Adjacent category	A different strategy focused on reducing harms of ongoing use.
D	Correct	Targets individuals with early signs of problem use.

7. Answer A Concept 5

A woman ~~who works as a hair stylist~~ says, "I know my drinking is hurting my health, and part of me wants to cut back, but it's how I relax, so I'm not sure." She has no plan or date to change. ~~Her salon has four chairs.~~ Which stage of change is she in?

Target word: stage of change **Decides:** Aware and ambivalent, with no plan.

A	Correct	She sees the problem and is ambivalent, without a concrete plan.
B	Confusion set	Preparation includes concrete plans soon; she has none.
C	Inverted operation	Precontemplation means not seeing a problem; she does.
D	Dropped element	Drops the need for actual behavior change.

8. Answer D Concept 5 • transfer

A man has set a quit date two weeks from now, removed alcohol from his home, and scheduled a clinic visit. Which stage is he in?

Target word: stage from concrete plans **Decides:** Specific plans with a near date, not yet changed.

A	Adjacent category	Action begins once he has actually changed the behavior.
B	Confusion set	He is past ambivalence; he has a plan.
C	Inverted operation	Maintenance follows months of sustained change.
D	Correct	Concrete steps and a near-term date, before sustained change.

9. Answer B Concept 6

A client ~~who drives a delivery truck~~ tells a counselor, “Everyone keeps saying I drink too much, but I don’t think it’s that bad.” ~~The counselor’s office has a large fish tank.~~ Which response best reflects motivational interviewing?

Target word: MI-consistent response **Decides:** Reflect and explore without confronting.

A	Inverted operation	Confrontation increases resistance.
B	Correct	A reflection plus an open question evokes his own reasons.
C	Absolute language	Evidence favors a collaborative approach.
D	Adjacent category	Lecturing and directing are not evoking his motivation.

10. Answer A Concept 7

A county health department ~~in a region known for its wineries~~ starts giving free naloxone kits and fentanyl test strips to people who use drugs. A council member ~~who owns a hardware store~~ worries the program will increase drug use. What does the evidence show?

Target word: effect of harm reduction **Decides:** Harm reduction lowers deaths without increasing use.

A	Correct	Harm reduction lowers risk and can connect people to care.
B	Confusion set	That describes abstinence-based treatment, not harm reduction.
C	Dropped element	Drops the point that harm reduction serves people who are still using.
D	Inverted operation	Research does not support this concern.

11. Answer A Concept 8

A patient with opioid use disorder ~~who works as a carpenter~~ wants a medication that blocks opioid effects and is not itself an opioid. He has completed detoxification and has been opioid-free for 10 days. ~~His clinic is next to a bakery.~~ Which medication fits?

Target word: choose by mechanism **Decides:** A blocker that is not an opioid agonist.

A	Correct	An opioid antagonist that blocks effects; it requires being opioid-free first.
B	Confusion set	A partial agonist, still an opioid.
C	Adjacent category	Naloxone reverses overdose; it is not a daily maintenance treatment.
D	Inverted operation	A full agonist—it activates receptors.

12. Answer D Concept 8 · transfer

A friend says, “Methadone treatment is just replacing one addiction with another.” What is the most accurate response?

Target word: role of agonist treatment **Decides:** Controlled agonist treatment reduces harm and overdose.

A	Inverted operation	Methadone is a full agonist; naltrexone is the blocker.
B	Adjacent category	That is naloxone.
C	Absolute language	Confuses dependence on a prescribed medicine with addiction.
D	Correct	MOUD is evidence-based treatment, not the compulsive, harmful use that defines addiction.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	10	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	1	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Tolerance, withdrawal, and addiction	Tolerance (needing more for the same effect) and withdrawal show physical dependence, which can occur with properly prescribed medicines; addiction (substance use disorder) is compulsive use despite harm and loss of control.	Equating physical dependence with addiction.	A patient on long-term prescribed medication who has withdrawal symptoms but no compulsive use.
2	The brain's reward pathway	Addictive substances increase dopamine signaling in the mesolimbic reward pathway; over time cues linked to use can trigger strong craving, while prefrontal control weakens.	Viewing addiction purely as a lack of willpower.	Craving triggered by people, places, or objects linked to past use.
3	Risk and protective factors	Risk factors (early use, family history, trauma, peer use, easy access) raise the chance of substance problems; protective factors (strong family bonds, school connection, supportive adults) lower it; neither guarantees the outcome.	Treating one risk factor as destiny, or ignoring protective factors.	A list of personal, family, and community conditions.
4	Universal, selective, and indicated prevention	Universal prevention targets a whole population; selective targets groups at higher risk; indicated targets individuals already showing early signs of use.	Mixing up selective (group risk) and indicated (individual early signs).	Who the program is delivered to.
5	Stages of change	Change moves through precontemplation (not considering change), contemplation (ambivalent), preparation (planning soon), action (actively changing), and maintenance (sustaining change); relapse is common and not a failure of the model.	Confusing contemplation (thinking about it) with preparation (concrete plans).	What the person says about their intentions and timeline.
6	Motivational interviewing	Motivational interviewing is a collaborative style that evokes the person's own reasons for change using open questions, affirmations, reflections, and summaries, and avoids confrontation and arguing.	Believing confronting denial is the most effective way to create change.	A person ambivalent about change and a helper choosing how to respond.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
7	Harm reduction	Harm reduction lowers the health risks of use without requiring abstinence first—for example naloxone distribution, syringe services, and fentanyl test strips—and it does not increase drug use.	Believing harm reduction encourages use.	A strategy that makes use safer rather than demanding immediate abstinence.
8	Medications for opioid use disorder	Methadone is a full opioid agonist, buprenorphine a partial agonist, and naltrexone an antagonist; MOUD reduces overdose deaths and is an evidence-based treatment, not “replacing one drug with another.”	Mixing up agonist and antagonist roles.	A medication that blocks vs. activates opioid receptors.

Course scope (public description): Understanding Substance Abuse and Addiction provides an overview of substance abuse causes, impact, prevention, and treatment. Students will understand the signs and symptoms of substance abuse and addiction and its impact on individuals, groups, and the community. Students will analyze relevant factors that initiate and reinforce substance abuse and addiction and describe evidence-based strategies for prevention, intervention, and treatment. There are no prerequisites for this course.